



KIAN RAVAEI

A FREE PEOPLE

for string quartet
and narrator

(score)

ÆI edition

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I. Opening.....	1
II. Indictment	8
III. Of Bondage and Freedom.....	21
IV. Declaration.....	28

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Commissioned by Mimir Chamber Music Festival, Seattle Chamber Music Society, and The Charlottesville Chamber Music Festival

PROGRAM NOTE

A Free People was commissioned by the Mimir Chamber Music Festival, Seattle Chamber Music Society, and Charlottesville Chamber Music Festival for the 250th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence. The first and last movements set the Declaration's opening and closing words, while the second movement deals with its longest, yet least often talked about, section: a list of grievances against a cruel and tyrannical king. Musical references from the Revolutionary era abound, including drum and fife music, bugle calls, the British patriotic song *Rule Britannia* (which is also the opening theme of Beethoven's *Wellington's Victory*), and a paraphrase of The Star-Spangled Banner. The unnarrated third movement, "Of Bondage and Freedom," reflects the history of the American people up to the present day, asking if we have lived up to the ideals of the Declaration over the last quarter of a millennium.

—Kian Ravaei

duration ca. 20'

TEXT

from the Declaration of Independence (1776)

I. Opening

The unanimous Declaration of the thirteen united States of America,
When in the Course of human events, it becomes necessary for one people to dissolve the political bands which have connected them with another, and to assume among the powers of the earth, the separate and equal station to which the Laws of Nature and of Nature's God entitle them, a decent respect to the opinions of mankind requires that they should declare the causes which impel them to the separation.

We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal, that they are endowed by their Creator with certain unalienable Rights, that among these are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness. That to secure these rights, Governments are instituted among Men, deriving their just powers from the consent of the governed, —That whenever any Form of Government becomes destructive of these ends, it is the Right of the People to alter or to abolish it, and to institute new Government, laying its foundation on such principles and organizing its powers in such form, as to them shall seem most likely to effect their Safety and Happiness. Prudence, indeed, will dictate that Governments long established should not be changed for light and transient causes; and accordingly all experience hath shewn, that mankind are more disposed to suffer, while evils are sufferable, than to right themselves by abolishing the forms to which they are accustomed. But when a long train of abuses and usurpations, pursuing invariably the same Object evinces a design to reduce them under absolute Despotism, it is their right, it is their duty, to throw off such Government, and to provide new Guards for their future security. Such has been the patient sufferance of these Colonies; and such is now the necessity which constrains them to alter their former Systems of Government.

II. Indictment

The history of the present King of Great Britain is a history of repeated injuries and usurpations, all having in direct object the establishment of an absolute Tyranny over these States. To prove this, let Facts be submitted to a candid world.

He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good.

He has dissolved Representative Houses repeatedly, for opposing with manly firmness his invasions on the rights of the people.

He has endeavoured to prevent the population of these States; for that purpose obstructing the Laws for Naturalization of Foreigners; refusing to pass others to encourage their migrations hither, and raising the conditions of new Appropriations of Lands.

He has made Judges dependent on his Will alone, for the tenure of their offices, and the amount and payment of their salaries.

He has erected a multitude of New Offices, and sent hither swarms of Officers to harrass our people, and eat out their substance.

He has combined with others to subject us to a jurisdiction foreign to our constitution, and unacknowledged by our laws; giving his Assent to their Acts of pretended Legislation:

For Quartering large bodies of armed troops among us:

For protecting them, by a mock Trial, from punishment for any Murders which they should commit on the Inhabitants of these States:

For cutting off our Trade with all parts of the world:

For imposing Taxes on us without our Consent:

For depriving us in many cases, of the benefits of Trial by Jury.

He has plundered our seas, ravaged our Coasts, burnt our towns, and destroyed the lives of our people.

He is at this time transporting large Armies of foreign Mercenaries to compleat the works of death, desolation and tyranny, already begun with circumstances of Cruelty & perfidy scarcely paralleled in the most barbarous ages, and totally unworthy the Head of a civilized nation.

A Prince, whose character is thus marked by every act which may define a Tyrant, is unfit to be the ruler of a free people.

III. Of Bondage and Freedom

(Narrator Tacet)

IV. Declaration

We, therefore, the Representatives of the united States of America, in General Congress, Assembled, appealing to the Supreme Judge of the world for the rectitude of our intentions, do, in the Name, and by Authority of the good People of these Colonies, solemnly publish and declare, That these United Colonies are, and of Right ought to be Free and Independent States; that they are Absolved from all Allegiance to the British Crown, and that all political connection between them and the State of Great Britain, is and ought to be totally dissolved; and that as Free and Independent States, they have full Power to levy War, conclude Peace, contract Alliances, establish Commerce, and to do all other Acts and Things which Independent States may of right do. And for the support of this Declaration, with a firm reliance on the protection of divine Providence, we mutually pledge to each other our Lives, our Fortunes and our sacred Honor.

This text is in the public domain.

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for the 250th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence

A FREE PEOPLE

for string quartet and narrator

Text from the Declaration
of Independence (1776)

Kian Ravaei
(2026)

I. Opening

Maestoso ♩ = 69

Violin I
mf resonant

Violin II
mf resonant

Viola
mf resonant

Violoncello
mf resonant

(↓ = cue narrator)

The unanimous Declaration of the
thirteen United States of America,
hold until narrator finishes

pizz.
f secco
pizz.
f secco
pizz.
f secco
pizz.
f secco
arco
p intense

p *f* *p* *f* *p* *f* *p* *f*

2

When in the Course
of human events...

9 arco

p intense
arco

p intense
arco

p intense

13

p

p

p

17

pp

pp

pp

pp

21 rit.

pp *p* *f* *p*

a tempo

We hold these truths
to be self-evident...

26 *cant.*

30 Brighter ♩ = 84

cant.

34

cant.

38

cant.

pp

pp

pp

cant.

42

46

mf

mf

mf

cant.

mf

accel. poco a poco

50

p

p

p

p

pp sub.

mf

Poco agitato ♩ = 104

56

pp

mf

64

mf

mf

pp

This system contains measures 64 through 71. It features four staves: two treble staves, a tenor staff in C3 (bass clef), and a bass staff. The key signature has two flats (B-flat and E-flat). The first treble staff has a melodic line with a *mf* dynamic at measure 65. The second treble staff has a melodic line with a *mf* dynamic at measure 66. The tenor staff has a rhythmic accompaniment. The bass staff has a melodic line with a *pp* dynamic at measure 65. The system ends with a double bar line at measure 71.

72

mf

mf

This system contains measures 72 through 79. It features four staves: two treble staves, a tenor staff in C3 (bass clef), and a bass staff. The key signature has two flats (B-flat and E-flat). The first treble staff has a melodic line with a *mf* dynamic at measure 73. The second treble staff has a melodic line with a *mf* dynamic at measure 74. The tenor staff has a rhythmic accompaniment. The bass staff has a melodic line with a *mf* dynamic at measure 73. The system ends with a double bar line at measure 79.

80

mf

This system contains measures 80 through 87. It features four staves: two treble staves, a tenor staff in C3 (bass clef), and a bass staff. The key signature has two flats (B-flat and E-flat). The first treble staff has a melodic line with a *mf* dynamic at measure 81. The second treble staff has a melodic line with a *mf* dynamic at measure 82. The tenor staff has a rhythmic accompaniment. The bass staff has a melodic line with a *mf* dynamic at measure 81. The system ends with a double bar line at measure 87.

Tempo I subito ♩ = 69

88

88

f *p*

f *p*

f *p*

f *p*

Such has been the patient sufferance...

95

95

rit.

Slower, freely ♩ = 54

99

99

lontano *pp* *ppp*

ten. *ten.* *ten.*

pp *ppp* *ppp*

pp *ppp* *ppp*

attacca

II. Indictment

Militaristic ♩ = 76 (♩ = 114)

Violin I *ff* *sost., vigoroso*

Violin II *ff* *sost., vigoroso*

Viola *ff* *sost., vigoroso*

Violoncello *ff* *sost., vigoroso*

strike with bow hair on the fingerboard

f *percussive*

strike with bow hair on the fingerboard

f *percussive*

(♩ = ♩ *sempre*)

5 *8va*

f *quasi fife*

f *quasi fife*

ord.

ff *quasi bugle*

10 *8va*

strike with bow hair on the fingerboard

f *percussive*

16 (8)

2 2 4 2

ord.
ff quasi bugle

3

21

8^{va}

strike with bow hair
on the fingerboard

f percussive

3

26 (8)

ff sost., vigoroso

ord.

ff sost., vigoroso

ord.

ff sost., vigoroso

ord.

sul pont.,
on the string

fpp

3

31

mf cant.

mf cant.

mf cant.

pp

sul pont., on the string

36

sul pont., on the string

pp

ord.

mf cant.

41

ord.

mf

sul pont., on the string

pp

ord.

mf cant.

46

(narrator stands up)

pizz.
p

51

The history of the present King...

p

57

p > distant bugle

p

62

67

71 (same tempo)

He has refused his Assent to Laws, the most wholesome and necessary for the public good.

hold until narrator finishes

hold until narrator finishes

hold until narrator finishes

hold until narrator finishes

arco 12

ff molto espr., ad lib.

He has dissolved Representative Houses
repeatedly, for opposing with manly firmness
his invasions on the rights of the people.

74

pp

mf

pp

77

ff

pp

ff

arco

ff molto espr., ad lib.

mf

ff

pp

81

pp

ff rough

after "states"

after "Foreigners"

after "hither"

3

14

and raising the conditions of
new Appropriations of Lands.

84 (no cue)

pp *ff* *pp*

ff *molto espr.*

ff *molto espr.*

He has made Judges dependent on his Will alone, for the tenure
of their offices, and the amount and payment of their salaries.

87

pp *mf* *p con vib.* *ff*

He has erected a multitude
of New Offices...

96

ff *pp* *p*

102

mf

ff sost., vigoroso

109

f quasi fife

f quasi fife

sul pont., on the string

fpp

114

ff quasi bugle

sul pont., on the string

pp sub.

118

ord. *ff* quasi bugle

ff quasi bugle

4

4

4

4

4

122

(narrator stands up)

f

sul pont., on the string

pp

f

pizz. (ord.)

p

4

4

4

4

4

4

127

He has combined with others...

ord.

p

p

p

4

4

4

4

4

4

133

For Quartering large bodies
of armed troops among us:

138

143

For protecting them, after "them" (no cue) after "trial" (no cue) after "murder" 3 (no cue) which they should commit on the inhabitants of these States:

$$ff \longrightarrow pp$$

pp

and destroyed the lives of our people.

molto sul pont.

He is at this time transporting...

154 (no cue)

ffpp

pp

ff

pp

molto sul pont.

159

(pp)

p grazioso

4 2

accel..... $\text{♩} = 152$

164

molto sul pont.

pp

169 accel..... $\text{♩} = 184$

molto sul pont.

pp

173 poco a poco al ord.....

poco a poco al ord.....

poco a poco al ord.....

poco a poco al ord.....

Tempo I subito (♩. = 76)

176 ord.

fff barbarous, secco

ord.

fff barbarous, secco

ord.

fff barbarous, secco

ord.

fff barbarous, secco

A Prince, whose character is thus marked by every act which may define a Tyrant, is unfit to be the ruler of a free people.

(narrator sits down)

(no cue)

181

attacca

III. Of Bondage and Freedom

poco

Dark, tense ♩ = 66

rit.

a tempo

poco stringendo

Violin I

Violin II

Viola

Violoncello

con sord.

pp poco espr.

con sord.

pp

cresc.

cresc.

♩ = 80

rit.

a tempo (♩ = 80)

con sord.

8

pp

cresc.

mf

pp

cresc.

mf

pp

cresc.

rit.

a tempo

15

mf

pp

f

mf

p espr.

cresc.

f

mf

p

cresc.

f

rit.

a tempo

rit.

Gently flowing ♩ = 92

22

p

con sord.

p

pp cant., semplice

p

pp

p

rit. a tempo

26

30

cresc.....

cresc.....

cresc..

35 rit. a tempo

mf p pp

mf p pp

mf p pp

40 rit. a tempo rit. Tempo I, dark ♩ = 66

mf p pp

mf p pp

mf p pp

mf sub. p espr.

pp senza sord.

47 poco rit. a tempo poco stringendo

cresc. cresc. cresc. cresc.

53 ♩ = 80 rit. a tempo (♩ = 80)

mf p cresc. mf p cresc. mf p cresc. mf p cresc.

59 rit. a tempo

mf p cresc. f mf p cresc. f mf p cresc. f

65 rit. a tempo rit. Gently flowing ♩ = 92 rit. a tempo

p p pp cant., semplice senza sord. p p pp p p pp

rit. a tempo

69

rit. a tempo

73

rit. a tempo

cresc.....

cresc.....

cresc.....

cresc..

78

rit. a tempo stringendo

mf

mf

mf

mf

cresc.....

cresc.....

cresc.....

cresc.....

rit.

Maestoso ♩ = 69

83

ff sempre

ff sempre

ff sempre

ff sempre

88

93

97

97 98 99 100

101

(narrator stands up)

rit.

mf

p

mf

p

mf

p

mf

p

attacca subito

101 102 103 104

IV. Declaration

Adagio teneramente ♩ = 54

We, therefore, the
Representatives...

Violin I

p dolce

Violin II

p

Viola

p

Violoncello

p

rit. a tempo

7

mf *p*

mf *p*

mf *p*

mf *p*

dolce

rit. a tempo

14

mf *pp*

mf *pp*

mf *pp*

mf *p espr.*

20

rit. a tempo rit.

mf

mf

mf

p dolce

p

26 a tempo (freely)

p lontano

pp

ppp

ten.

pp

ppp

pp

ppp

